wrote. ‘The chamber was probably intended as a resting place for persons passing the Ghat, as there is a stone seat all round the bottom of the walls.’

But it was Sykes who was guilty of carelessness, because he failed to notice that the back wall of the cave had originally carried a line of eight life-sized figures in semi-relief which had been so thoroughly hacked away that only bits of their feet remained, although each was identified by a short inscription.

Like other antiquarians of his time, Sykes could make no sense of what he termed the ‘Boodh letters’ of the inscriptions. But he did note ‘the very singular fact that, in comparing Boodh inscriptions with very ancient Sanskrit inscriptions, Boodh letters are discovered in the latter, and the prevalence of the Boodh letters is in the ratio of the antiquity of the Sanskrit letters … Can it be that these Boodh letters are a very ancient form of the Sanskrit alphabet, and that the inscriptions themselves are in the Sanskrit language?’ This was spot on. The Brahmi script of his ‘Boodh letters’ is indeed the prototype of modern Devanagari.

Another nine years passed before James Prinsep proved with his deciphering of Brahmi that Sykes’s conjecture was correct, and decades before parts of the Naneghat inscription were satisfactorily read by the Bombay-based German epigraphist Georg Bühler – enough to show that this was the work of a powerful widowed queen named Naganika who had married a king named Satakarni, son of the illustrious king Simuka. Her husband was now dead, but they had had four sons, one dead and one who was now the ruler. It was their portraits in stone that had originally lined the back wall of the cave. Queen Naganika’s husband Satakarni had evidently enjoyed a long and prosperous reign because most of the inscription was taken up with a detailed account of the many vows, ceremonies and Vedic sacrifices they had together performed, all of which had entailed the